

May, Might & Could

CEFR B1

Lesson Pack · summary, worksheet & answer key

Quick answer

'May', 'might' and 'could' all say something is possible. The differences are small:

- 1** May — possible; also formal permission (It may be true; You may go).
- 2** Might — possible, slightly less certain (She might be at home).
- 3** Could — possible, one option among several (It could be the traffic).

For a negative possibility use 'may not' / 'might not' (He might not know). 'Couldn't' means impossible, not 'possibly not'.

At a glance

Meaning	Form	Example
Present / future possibility	may / might / could + base verb	It might rain later.
Negative possibility	may not / might not + base verb	She might not come.
Formal permission	may + base verb	You may leave the room.
Past guess	may / might / could + have + participle	He may have forgotten.

Learning objectives

- Can use 'may', 'might' and 'could' for present and future possibility (CEFR B1).
- Can form negative possibility with 'may not' / 'might not' and distinguish it from 'couldn't' (impossible).
- Can recognise 'may' for formal permission.



Practice worksheet

Circle the correct option. May, Might & Could · CEFR B1

Name: _____

Date: _____

1. Take a coat — it ____ get cold tonight.

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| A. might | B. might to |
| C. mights | D. must to |

2. I'm not sure where she is — she ____ be at work.

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|---------|-----------|
| A. may | B. may to |
| C. mays | D. is may |

3. Perhaps they don't know yet — they ____ have heard.

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| A. might not | B. couldn't |
| C. mustn't | D. can't |

4. It's a formal exam. 'You ____ begin now,' said the teacher.

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| A. may | B. might |
| C. could | D. must to |

5. Where's Tom? He ____ have missed the train.

- | | |
|-----------|-------------|
| A. might | B. might to |
| C. mights | D. may to |

6. Don't eat that — it ____ be past its date.

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|-----------|-------------|
| A. could | B. could to |
| C. coulds | D. can to |

7. That ____ be John at the door — he's abroad this week.

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|----------|----------|
| A. might | B. may |
| C. can't | D. could |

8. Correct this: 'She might forgot the meeting.'

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| A. She might have forgotten the meeting. | B. She might forgets the meeting. |
| C. She might to forget the meeting. | D. The sentence is already correct. |

9. The keys ____ be in my bag; let me check.

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|------------|-----------|
| A. may | B. may to |
| C. must to | D. mays |

10. Which sentence is a guess about the PAST?

- | | |
|--------------------------------|-------------------------------|
| A. It might rain tomorrow. | B. She may be busy right now. |
| C. He could have left already. | D. They might not agree. |

Answer key

Correct answers with explanations · for the teacher

1. **A. might** — Possibility takes 'might' + base verb: 'it might get cold'.
2. **A. may** — 'May' expresses possibility: 'She may be at work'.
3. **A. might not** — A negative guess takes 'might not': 'they might not have heard'.
4. **A. may** — Formal permission takes 'may': 'You may begin now'.
5. **A. might** — A past guess takes 'might have + participle': 'He might have missed the train'.
6. **A. could** — 'Could' expresses possibility here: 'it could be past its date'.
7. **C. can't** — Impossibility takes 'can't': 'That can't be John — he's abroad'.
8. **A. She might have forgotten the meeting.** — A past guess needs 'might have + participle': 'She might have forgotten'.
9. **A. may** — 'May' expresses possibility: 'They may be in my bag'.
10. **C. He could have left already.** — 'Could have left' is a guess about the past.